

Halogric Research Integration Series

THE SPIRITUALIST MOVEMENT

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Fox Sisters, Seance Culture, Lily Dale, Theosophy, and the Direct Line to the New Age

*On the night of March 31, 1848, in a small house in Hydesville, New York,
two girls asked a dead man to knock once for yes and twice for no.
He knocked.*

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Introduction -- The Moment That Changed Everything: Hydesville, 1848

The house at Hydesville, Wayne County, New York, was unremarkable in every physical respect -- a small wooden farmhouse occupied since December 1847 by the Fox family: John Fox, his wife Margaret, and their two youngest daughters, Margaretta (Maggie), age 14, and Catherine (Kate), age 11. The previous tenant had left after complaining of unexplained nocturnal sounds -- rappings and disturbances with no identifiable source. On the night of March 31, 1848, Kate Fox addressed the sounds directly. "Here, Mr. Splitfoot, do as I do," she said -- and clapped her hands. The sounds clapped back. Maggie snapped her fingers; the sounds snapped back. The girls established a code: one rap for yes, two for no. Through this code, the presence communicated that it was the spirit of a murdered peddler whose body was buried in the cellar. Excavations in subsequent years produced human remains.

Within weeks, the story had spread through New York State. Within months, it was national news. Within a year, the Fox sisters were giving public demonstrations to audiences of hundreds in Rochester and New York City. The rappings followed them -- occurring in public venues, before skeptical audiences, in conditions designed to prevent fraud. In 1888, Maggie Fox published a signed confession in the *New York World* claiming that the rappings had been produced by cracking the joints of their toes and knees. The confession devastated the Spiritualist movement. However, a year later, Maggie recanted her confession, claiming it had been purchased from her by anti-Spiritualist interests. The question of what actually happened in Hydesville remains genuinely unresolved -- not because the evidence is unclear, but because both the phenomenon's reality and the confession's reliability are contested.

The Fox Sisters -- Kate, Maggie, and the Rappings

Kate Fox (Catherine, 1837-1892) and Maggie Fox (Margaretta, 1833-1893) became the first celebrities of American Spiritualism -- traveling, performing before audiences, and submitting to investigation by scientists, journalists, and skeptics. Their older sister Leah Fox (1814-1890) became their manager and promoter. The phenomenon they brought into public consciousness sparked a movement that within a decade had 11 million adherents in the United States and Britain, multiple national newspapers devoted to Spiritualist topics, and serious scientific investigation from some of the most eminent figures of the era.

The sisters' lives were complicated by the movement they accidentally started: both Kate and Maggie struggled with alcoholism; both were subjected to relentless public scrutiny; both eventually sold their stories in ways that contradicted each other. Kate's gift was considered the stronger and more consistent of the two. The 1888 confession and 1889 recantation meant that Maggie died having both confessed and recanted -- a position of maximum ambiguity that perfectly captures the Spiritualist movement's fundamental epistemological problem: the phenomenon consistently refuses to either fully establish itself or fully go away.

The Spread of Seance Culture Across America (1848-1870)

The Spiritualist movement that emerged from Hydesville was one of the fastest-growing religious movements in American history. By the 1850s, séances were being held in parlors across the United States; by the 1860s, Spiritualism had become a mass cultural phenomenon with its own newspapers, its own organizational structure (the National Spiritualist Association of Churches was founded in 1893), its own theology (centered on the continuity of consciousness after death and the possibility of communication across the boundary), and its own celebrity practitioners.

Spiritualism's social dimensions: The movement had a specific relationship with the social reform movements of its era -- particularly women's suffrage and abolitionism. Women could be mediums in an era when women could not hold most public roles, and the authority that came from spirit communication provided a legitimate public voice that other channels denied. Susan B. Anthony was a frequent visitor to Lily Dale. The séance circle, with its egalitarian seating and shared purpose, was itself a social experiment in equality. The connection between Spiritualism and social reform is one of the most consistently overlooked aspects of the movement's history -- documented in *Spiritualism's Place: Reformers, Seekers, and Séances in Lily Dale* (Cornell University Press, 2024).

Spiritualism Crosses the Atlantic -- Britain and Europe

Spiritualism reached Britain in the early 1850s and developed its own distinctly British character -- more intellectually oriented, more connected to the established scientific community, and ultimately more productive of the serious scientific investigation that produced the Society for Psychical Research. The British movement attracted engagement from figures including Alfred Russel Wallace (co-developer of evolution by natural selection), William Crookes (discoverer of thallium), Arthur Conan Doyle, and members of Parliament and the aristocracy. The British Spiritualist movement also produced some of the most extensively documented physical mediums of the era -- particularly Daniel Dunglas Home (1833-1886), the Scottish-American medium who was never definitively exposed as a fraud despite decades of investigation, and whose phenomena (levitation, fire handling, accordion playing without touching) were witnessed by hundreds of credible observers.

The Major Figures -- Believers, Investigators, Skeptics

Arthur Conan Doyle (1859-1930): The creator of Sherlock Holmes -- the most famous fictional rationalist in literature -- was one of the most committed and most public believers in Spiritualism of his era. After losing his son Kingsley and his brother Innes in World War I, Doyle became convinced through séance communication that he had maintained contact with them. He wrote *The History of Spiritualism* (1926), toured the world lecturing on the subject, and staked his considerable public reputation on the reality of spirit communication. His commitment was not credulous -- he investigated extensively before accepting, and his acceptance was genuine, deeply felt, and never recanted.

Harry Houdini (1874-1926): The world's most famous escape artist and illusionist was also the most dedicated scientific skeptic of Spiritualist claims of his era. His motivation was not simple debunking -- Houdini was desperately attempting to contact his deceased mother, whom he had loved profoundly, and was willing to believe if he could find one genuine medium. He never did. He exposed fraud after fraud -- including the medium Mina "Margery" Crandon, who had been endorsed by prominent scientists. His friendship with Conan Doyle, strained by their disagreements about the Margery case, is one of the most poignant intellectual relationships of the period.

William James (1842-1910): The philosopher and psychologist -- one of the founders of American psychology -- co-founded the American Society for Psychical Research (ASPR) in 1885. James believed that the phenomena of Spiritualism deserved serious scientific investigation and that dismissing them without investigation was scientifically irresponsible. He investigated the medium Leonora Piper extensively over several years -- hiring private detectives to follow her, investigating her background for fraud, and subjecting her sessions to rigorous observation. He concluded that "the phenomena are real" while remaining uncertain about their ultimate explanation. Leonora Piper (1857-1950): The Boston medium whose work convinced William James. Frederic Myers (1843-1901): Cambridge scholar and co-founder of the British Society for Psychical Research; his posthumous work *Human Personality and Its Survival of Bodily Death* (1903) remains one of the most serious scholarly treatments of the psychical research evidence.

The Society for Psychical Research -- What the Investigators Found

The Society for Psychical Research (SPR), founded in London in 1882, and its American counterpart the ASPR (founded 1885) represented the most sustained scientific investigation of Spiritualist phenomena in history. Their investigators -- who included Cambridge classicists, philosophers, physicists, and psychologists -- subjected mediums to systematic investigation over decades. Their findings were neither the wholesale endorsement that Spiritualists hoped for nor the wholesale dismissal that skeptics expected. The most carefully documented phenomena -- particularly the "cross-correspondences" (interlocking fragments of complex messages received simultaneously by different mediums in different locations) and the accuracy of specific mediums including Leonora Piper -- could not be explained by any known conventional mechanism while also presenting evidence that fraud was present in many other cases.

The cross-correspondences: From 1901 onward, different automatic writing mediums in different locations produced fragmentary messages that only made sense when assembled together -- as if an external intelligence was distributing a single complex message across multiple human receivers to prove that no single individual could have composed it. The SPR investigators who studied these correspondences over two decades considered them among the strongest available evidence for survival of consciousness. The cases remain genuinely unresolved by any conventional explanation.

Fraud, Exposure, and the Complicated Truth

The history of Spiritualism is also a history of fraud -- extensive, documented, and often egregious. Physical mediums who produced materialized spirit forms were repeatedly caught using confederates, hidden props, and specific sleight-of-hand techniques. Spirit photographers were revealed to be using double exposures and props. The Fox sisters' own confession (however subsequently retracted) placed the origins of the entire movement in question. And yet: the fraud did not explain everything. The investigators who exposed fraudulent mediums most rigorously -- including Houdini himself -- consistently found cases they could not explain by conventional means. The most honest available assessment remains that fraud was prevalent, that genuine unexplained phenomena also occurred, and that the two coexisted in a way that makes simple categorical judgment impossible.

The Maggie Fox confession is instructive precisely because of its subsequent retraction. If the confession was true, Spiritualism began as fraud. If the retraction was true, the confession was itself a fraud -- purchased from a vulnerable woman by anti-Spiritualist interests. Both possibilities have been argued seriously by credible investigators. The truth is probably more complicated than either: some phenomena were fraudulent, some were not, and the human desire for contact with the dead created an environment in which both genuine and fraudulent practitioners could flourish simultaneously.

The Seance -- Complete Historical Step-by-Step

The séance (from the French "seoir" -- to sit; literally "a sitting") is the central ceremony of Spiritualist practice -- the structured gathering in which a medium facilitates communication between living participants and the spirits of the deceased. The following step-by-step reflects historical séance practice as documented by investigators from the 1850s through the early 20th century.

Preparation: The medium selects a private room. A round or oval table is preferred. Chairs are arranged so that all participants can touch hands, creating an unbroken circle of human contact. Lighting is reduced significantly -- most historical séances were conducted in near-darkness or complete darkness, with a single red lamp as the

exception. Participants may be asked to sit for 30-60 minutes before the medium enters, singing hymns or sitting in silent expectation.

Step 1 -- The Opening Prayer: The medium or a designated leader opens with prayer -- acknowledging the divine, requesting protection, and inviting only loving spirits to communicate. This opening prayer is the sacred threshold of the ceremony.

Step 2 -- The Circle is Formed: Participants join hands around the table. The instruction is to maintain contact throughout and not to break the circle.

Step 3 -- Calling the Guide: Most developed mediums worked with a specific "spirit guide" -- a deceased person who served as the medium's intermediary with the spirit world. The medium calls the guide by name and waits for signs of the guide's presence.

Step 4 -- The Manifestations: Depending on the medium's specific gifts, manifestations might include: rapping or knocking sounds responding to yes/no questions; table levitation; trumpet phenomenon (a metal trumpet moving through the darkened room, voices emerging from it); materialization (visible spirit forms); direct voice (voices heard in the room distinct from the medium's voice); or the medium entering trance and speaking in another's voice.

Step 5 -- Communication: Questions are asked of the spirits -- typically through the guide first, who relays them. Responses come through rapping codes, through the medium's speech, or through written messages. The most evidential communications provide specific information unknown to the medium that is subsequently verified.

Step 6 -- The Closing: The medium signals the session's end. The circle is formally closed with prayer, thanking the spirits and formally releasing them.

Step 7 -- The Return: The medium, if they have been in deep trance, requires time to reorient to ordinary consciousness. Participants are advised not to rush the medium's return.

Automatic Writing -- Complete Step-by-Step

Automatic writing -- the practice of allowing the hand to write without the ordinary conscious mind directing it, with the intention that the writing expresses spirit communication -- is one of the most widely practiced and most personally accessible of all Spiritualist and psychical techniques. Unlike the séance, which requires a medium and a group, automatic writing can be practiced alone. Some of the most important Spiritualist communications were received through automatic writing -- including the cross-correspondences studied by the SPR.

Step 1 -- Preparation: Sit at a table with paper and pen. The pen should be light and comfortable.

Step 2 -- Enter Receptivity: Breathe deeply and deliberately for several minutes. Allow ordinary conscious thinking to quiet. Do not try to blank the mind -- simply allow thoughts to pass without following them.

Step 3 -- Hand on Paper: Rest the hand and pen lightly on the paper. Do not press. The hand should feel as though it is floating rather than resting.

Step 4 -- Allow Movement: When movement begins, do not try to read what is being written. Keep the eyes slightly averted or closed if possible. Conscious reading interrupts the flow by re-engaging the analytical mind.

Step 5 -- Continue Without Judgment: Automatic writing typically begins as random marks or loops before becoming letters, then words, then coherent content. The transition may take multiple sessions. Do not stop and analyze mid-session.

Step 6 -- The Closing: After 20-30 minutes, or when the movement stops naturally, formally close the session -- a brief prayer or statement of closing that releases the connection and marks the return to ordinary consciousness.

Step 7 -- Review: Read what was written after full return to ordinary consciousness. Note what is recognizable as your own thought patterns and what feels genuinely different -- in voice, in information, in character.

Spirit Photography -- The Most Contested Practice

Spirit photography -- the claim that photographs could capture images of deceased persons invisible to the naked eye -- was one of the most contested and most consistently fraudulent practices of the Spiritualist movement, while also being one of the most culturally significant. Beginning in the 1860s, photographers who claimed the ability to capture spirit images charged grieving relatives -- particularly those who had lost loved ones in the Civil War -- for photographs that showed the faces of deceased family members hovering near the living subject. The techniques for producing these images were well-documented by skeptical investigators: double exposures, superimposed negatives, and confederates in white fabric.

Despite the extensive documentation of fraud, spirit photography's cultural significance is real. It represents the first systematic attempt to use technology (photography) as a tool for communicating with the dead -- and it established a pattern that continues into the contemporary era with electronic voice phenomena (EVP), thermal cameras, and digital photograph anomalies. Every era produces its own technological version of the spirit photography phenomenon.

Lily Dale, New York -- The Living Spiritualist Community

Lily Dale Assembly is a small gated community on the shores of Cassadaga Lake in western New York State -- founded in 1879 as the Cassadaga Lake Free Association, a camp and meeting place for Spiritualists and Freethinkers. It is the oldest and largest Spiritualist community in the United States and the world. Listed on the National Register of Historic Places in 2022 as a historic district, Lily Dale has a year-round population of approximately 275, with over 50 registered mediums living and working in the community. The 2025 summer season runs June 20 through August 31; approximately 22,000 visitors arrive annually. Cornell University Press published *Spiritualism's Place: Reformers, Seekers, and Séances in Lily Dale* (2024), the most comprehensive recent scholarly treatment of the community's history and its relationship to women's suffrage, social reform, and the development of American religion.

The Stump: The most iconic location at Lily Dale is the Stump -- a large outdoor amphitheater built around a massive tree stump in a forest clearing. Twice daily during the summer season, registered mediums give public spirit messages at the Stump -- standing before the assembled audience and delivering specific communications to specific audience members. The Stump readings are free and open to all visitors. Private readings: Visitors can book private one-on-one sessions with registered mediums, who work through clairvoyance (seeing), clairsaudience (hearing), or psychometry (reading objects held by the sitter). The Healing Temple offers free spiritual healing sessions. The Marion H. Skidmore Library contains the largest collection of Spiritualist books in the world. The community headquarters of the National Spiritualist Association of Churches (founded 1893) is located at Lily Dale.

The Direct Line -- Spiritualism to Theosophy

The Theosophical Society was founded in New York City in 1875 by Helena Petrovna Blavatsky (1831-1891) and Colonel Henry Steel Olcott -- emerging directly from the Spiritualist milieu of the 1870s as a more philosophically ambitious attempt to understand and systematize the phenomena that Spiritualism had been documenting. Blavatsky arrived in New York in 1873, immediately involved herself in Spiritualist circles, and within two years had founded the Theosophical Society with the explicit goal of moving beyond the phenomena of Spiritualism toward a complete synthesis of world religions, occult philosophy, and the hidden wisdom she claimed to have received from a group of advanced spiritual beings she called the Mahatmas or Masters.

Isis Unveiled (1877) and The Secret Doctrine (1888) -- Blavatsky's two major works -- established the Theosophical framework that would directly influence every subsequent Western esoteric movement. The Secret Doctrine introduced concepts (the Akashic Records, Root Races, cosmic evolution, the astral and other planes of existence) that became foundational vocabulary for the New Age movement a century later. The Mahatma Letters controversy: Blavatsky claimed to receive teachings from Masters in Tibet through letters that "precipitated" (appeared physically in closed locations). An 1884 SPR investigation concluded that the letters were fraudulent, produced through hidden compartments. Blavatsky disputed this conclusion. The controversy was never definitively resolved. Despite the controversies, Theosophy's influence on Western spirituality is incalculable -- it introduced Hindu and Buddhist concepts (karma, reincarnation, chakras, the higher self) to Western audiences decades before those concepts became widely known.

Helena Blavatsky and Theosophy's Core Teachings

The Akashic Records: Blavatsky described a non-physical "substance" called Akasha (from the Sanskrit term for space or ether) in which every event, thought, and experience that has ever occurred in the universe is permanently recorded. The Akashic Records are the complete history of everything -- accessible to sufficiently developed practitioners through specific meditative and psychic techniques. Edgar Cayce's "Hall of Records" readings, the channeled library accessed by many New Age practitioners, and the contemporary concept of "accessing the Akashic Records" all derive from this Theosophical concept.

The Astral Plane: Theosophy formalized the concept of the astral plane -- a non-physical dimension of existence interpenetrating the physical world, in which thought-forms exist, in which the recently dead initially reside, and to which consciousness can travel in out-of-body experiences, dreams, and meditative states. The astral body -- a subtle body coexisting with the physical -- is the vehicle through which this travel occurs. This vocabulary became standard in virtually all subsequent Western esoteric traditions. **The Seven Planes:** Theosophy organized existence into seven interpenetrating planes or dimensions (physical, astral, mental, causal, and three higher spiritual planes) -- each with its own inhabitants, its own laws, and its own relationship to human consciousness. **Root Races:** The most controversial Theosophical concept -- Blavatsky described a sequence of seven "Root Races" of humanity, each corresponding to a different evolutionary stage. This concept was later misappropriated by Nazi ideology. Modern Theosophists have generally distanced themselves from the Root Race teachings.

Theosophy to the New Age -- Besant, Bailey, and the Transmission Chain

Annie Besant (1847-1933): After Blavatsky's death, Annie Besant became the dominant figure in the Theosophical Society. A former atheist and women's rights activist who converted to Theosophy after reviewing The Secret Doctrine, Besant expanded the Society's global reach, collaborated with C.W. Leadbeater on clairvoyant investigations that produced detailed maps of the astral plane and descriptions of chakras and subtle bodies, and

identified the young Jiddu Krishnamurti as the new World Teacher -- a claim Krishnamurti himself eventually rejected.

Alice Bailey (1880-1949): A student of Theosophy who claimed from 1919 onward to receive dictated teachings from a Tibetan Master called Djwhal Khul. Bailey's 24 volumes of received teachings systematized the Theosophical cosmology into the most complete and most influential version of the Ascended Master teachings. Bailey introduced the term "New Age" in its contemporary sense, describing an imminent transition from the Piscean Age to the Aquarian Age that would transform human consciousness. Her influence on the New Age movement is primary and largely unacknowledged. The New Age movement that emerged in the 1960s-1980s -- the crystals, the channeling, the ascended masters, the chakras, the cosmic evolution narrative, the Aquarian Age concept -- is Theosophy's concepts, simplified, commercialized, and detached from their intellectual apparatus. The direct line: Fox sisters -- American Spiritualism -- Blavatsky/Theosophy -- Besant/Bailey -- New Age.

Channeling -- The New Age Successor to the Seance

Channeling -- the New Age term for what Spiritualism called mediumship -- is the practice of receiving and transmitting communication from non-physical beings or intelligences through the medium of a human practitioner. The differences between Spiritualist mediumship and New Age channeling are primarily terminological and cosmological rather than practical: the medium who goes into trance and speaks in another's voice at a Lily Dale séance and the channeler who speaks as Abraham through Esther Hicks on a New Age stage are doing structurally identical things.

Edgar Cayce, Jane Roberts/Seth, and Abraham-Hicks

Edgar Cayce (1877-1945): The "Sleeping Prophet" of Virginia Beach -- a devout Christian who, from 1901 onward, entered self-induced trances in which he provided medical diagnoses and treatments for patients he had never met, and later cosmological readings about past lives, Atlantis, the Akashic Records, and the future. Cayce's readings -- over 14,000 of them, recorded by stenographers -- constitute one of the largest bodies of channeled material in history. Many of his medical diagnoses proved accurate and some of his treatment recommendations anticipated later conventional medical findings. The Association for Research and Enlightenment (ARE), established to maintain and disseminate his readings, continues operating in Virginia Beach.

Jane Roberts / Seth (1963-1984): Jane Roberts, a housewife and poet from Elmira, New York, began receiving communications in 1963 from an entity identifying itself as Seth -- "an energy personality essence no longer focused in physical reality." The Seth material presented a comprehensive metaphysical system: the nature of consciousness, the multidimensional nature of the self, the construction of physical reality through belief and consciousness, and the continuing evolution of the soul across multiple existences. Seth's statement -- "You create your own reality" -- became one of the most influential phrases in New Age thought and is a direct ancestor of the Law of Attraction as taught by Abraham-Hicks and popularized by The Secret.

Abraham-Hicks: Esther Hicks has channeled the collective intelligence called Abraham since the 1980s. The Abraham teachings -- most widely known through the book *Ask and It Is Given* and the film *The Secret* -- are the most commercially successful channeled material of the contemporary era and represent the most direct line between the Hydesville rappings and the mainstream contemporary spiritual marketplace. The Law of Attraction as a contemporary practice derives from Fox sisters -- American Spiritualism -- Blavatsky/Theosophy -- Alice Bailey -- Seth/Jane Roberts -- Abraham/Esther Hicks.

The Haligrity Lens -- Ancestor Contact and Spirit Communication

The Spiritualist Movement offers Haligrity a 175-year documented laboratory of human experience with spirit communication -- including both its genuine phenomena and its documented frauds -- that illuminates what the tradition holds about the mechanics of ancestor contact and the specific conditions under which spirit communication appears to be possible.

The most careful investigators -- William James, Frederic Myers, Richard Hodgson, Eleanor Sidgwick -- consistently found themselves unable to explain certain phenomena through any known conventional mechanism while also finding evidence of fraud in many cases. Their conclusion was not that all Spiritualism was fraud and not that the survival hypothesis was confirmed, but that something genuine was occurring in at least some cases, and that the genuine phenomenon was worth continued serious investigation. This is a scientifically reasonable conclusion -- and it remains the most honest available assessment of the evidence 175 years later.

The Haligrity ancestor altar practice is not Spiritualism. It does not claim to produce verifiable spirit communication or to provide information unknown to the practitioner. What it holds is: that the ancestral connection is real, that the attention paid to the ancestral dimension of life produces effects that cannot be explained by purely biological models of identity, and that the specific daily practice of acknowledging, feeding, and speaking to one's ancestors maintains a relationship that has consequences in the practitioner's living experience. The Spiritualist tradition's 175-year investigation is the most extensive available documentation of what happens when human beings take the question of continued consciousness seriously enough to investigate it systematically.

The Fox sisters asked a dead man to knock. He knocked. The investigators arrived. The scientists arrived. The magicians arrived. The frauds arrived. And through all of it -- through every exposure, every confession, every recantation -- the phenomenon refused to entirely go away. The Stump at Lily Dale still draws thousands every summer. The mediums still stand and deliver specific information to specific people in the audience about specific deceased individuals. The Akashic Records are still being accessed. Seth's Jane Roberts is still in print. The question is not whether the phenomenon exists -- the documented evidence is too consistent for that. The question is what it is. And that question remains open. Grand Rising.